Hawaiki Hōu

Artificial Intelligence or Augmented Intelligence?

In the intelligence era, think of Facebook, Google, Apple and Amazon as digital countries, colonising the digital landscape. They have leaders, infrastructure and laws controlling data within walled gardens. State use of AI creates a further sovereignty challenge. Automated public systems can make Indigenous peoples more visible to government decision-making while limiting their authority over the data, models and interpretations that shape those decisions. Where is our digital country and the rangatira to guide it?

Digital sovereignty begins with digital whenua. Indigenous peoples cannot fully control data when it is stored, processed and governed on infrastructure owned by others. It needs Indigenous-controlled servers, storage, computing capacity, platforms and rules. Robust frameworks already exist, including Māori Data Sovereignty, the CARE Principles and OCAP® (Ownership, Control, Access and Possession). They guide collective benefit, authority, responsibility, ethics and community control. The challenge is turning these principles into working digital spaces. The Tāne Te Kaihanga framework was designed specifically to bridge the digital gap between theory and Indigenous-governed platforms. It translates Indigenous governance principles into a Māori UI/UX design aesthetic, where mātauranga shapes how people see, navigate, authorise and benefit from their data.

This paper introduces Hawaiki Hōu as a Māori-led platform for digital whenua, demonstrating how AI, blockchain, distributed computing and open-source infrastructure can support Māori and other Indigenous peoples to govern their data. AI operates as augmented intelligence: a Māori-governed helper that makes data's value, movement and meaning visible to whānau, hapū and iwi. Blockchain records agreed consent, access, provenance and responsibility. Homeostatic methods identify imbalance alongside community strengths, supporting culturally grounded responses and holistic wellbeing. We can build this today; we have the skills and technology to make it so. What is lacking is imagination. Tāne Te Kaihanga offers a spark of that imagination.